

Is there life on Mars?

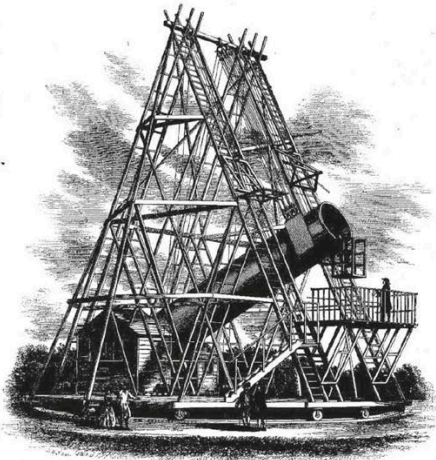
Historically, many people have believed that a race of creatures live on Mars. Representations have appeared in books, artwork, comics, on the radio, on television and in films, in many different forms. Do any of these creatures actually exist? No!



William Herschel

Two hundred years ago

In the 1780s, William Herschel observed seasonal changes around the Martian poles and noted that its inhabitants “probably enjoy a situation in many respects similar to our own”.



Herschel's 12-m (40-ft) telescope

In the papers

In the 1920s, a newspaper report on the Martians claimed they would have “very large noses and ears and immense lung development... Their legs are poorly developed, because matter on Mars weighs less than here”.

A big prize!

In 1900, the French Guzman prize offered an award of 100,000 francs for the first person to make contact with extraterrestrials. Terms actually excluded contact with Martians as it was believed to be too easy!



Camille Flammarion's (founder of the Société Astronomique) “Flat Earth” woodcut influenced Clara Goguet Guzman to offer the prize.

